

The Indian EXPRESS

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RAMNATH GOENKA

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BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

At BRICS, keep difficult conversations alive

THE 18TH BRICS Summit comes when wars, disrupted energy supplies and soaring costs are fragmenting the world order. At the same time, the grouping has expanded, and the diversity of its participants and interests gives the summit a special significance. For instance, Iran, Saudi Arabia and the UAE, which became full members more than two years ago, are embroiled in competition and conflict, and have divergent interests. Presidents Vladimir Putin of Russia and Xi Jinping of China are both participating. India, whose foreign policy has long rested on the idea that strategic autonomy is best preserved by maintaining relationships across the spectrum, has a strong interest in making such a forum work. Delhi knows that there is great value in keeping difficult conversations alive.

For Delhi, the summit is a test of whether it can advance its own and the forum's interests — through more resilient supply chains and greater use of national currencies in trade. These can give countries greater room to navigate a global financial system that is still disoriented and unsettled by the weaponisation of tariffs, over the last year and a half, by US President Donald Trump. Greater economic exchange within the bloc, or more broadly, within the Global South, however, does not make BRICS an anti-Western alliance. It reflects a desire among its members to trade freely, secure supplies from multiple sources and push for reform of global institutions.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has already met President Putin in a bilateral focused on boosting trade, defence, energy and critical minerals. The highlight of the summit is bound to be the meeting between Modi and Xi, in what will be the Chinese president's first visit to India since the Galwan clashes and the escalation of border tensions. While the two countries are rebuilding ties and Chinese investment has begun to return to India, the relationship remains fraught. India aims to reduce its economic dependence on China even as Chinese imports are deeply embedded in its manufacturing supply chains. Xi's presence in Delhi offers an opportunity to broaden cooperation and temper the edges of the competition. That is also the larger promise of BRICS. India's strategy should be to make it a more useful forum rather than just a bloc that ranges itself against the West, focusing on practical collaboration and strengthening its credibility as a voice of the Global South. A successful summit will be one that leaves India with more room for manoeuvre, fewer vulnerabilities and more channels through which a conversation can be sustained between countries that agree with each other, and also disagree.

For Bihar flood problem, solution lies beyond

BIHAR RECEIVED 27 per cent below-normal rainfall between June 1 and the first week of September. Even then, large parts of the state are under water. The Ganga, Gandak, Kosi, Budhi Gandak, Punpun and Ghaghra have all risen above danger levels in different stretches. A combination of high upstream river flows and erratic weather — spells of heavy, localised rainfall amid an overall rainfall deficit — has contributed to the rivers spilling over their banks. The unusually high level of the Ganga also created a “backwater effect” in the Gandak and Punpun. Since these rivers drain into the Ganga, its high water level made it difficult for them to discharge their water. As a result, water backed up in the tributaries, adding to the flooding.

Since colonial times, flood-prone Bihar has tried to contain its rivers within defined channels through embankments. But embankments separate rivers from their floodplains, while continuous silt deposition raises riverbeds and reduces channel capacity. When an embankment breaches, the artificially contained water can rush into homes and fields. Bihar, therefore, needs to revisit the idea that higher or stronger embankments will *ipso facto* contain floods. Embankment maintenance must be accompanied by the restoration of drainage channels, protection of floodplains, better land-use planning, restoration of wetlands, and deployment of early-warning systems. The Ganga Basin River Management Plan, implemented for more than a decade, acknowledges these imperatives. But the persistent monsoon floods in Bihar underline that much needs to be done to give the river space to spread safely during periods of high discharge. Addressing Bihar's concerns will require greater coordination between the riverine states on reservoir releases.

Bihar has long argued that the Farakka barrage and the India-Bangladesh Ganga Water Sharing Treaty have compounded the state's river-management challenges. It contends that the barrage has altered the Ganga's flow regime, affecting the movement and deposition of sediment load. The extent to which this contributes to floods in Bihar remains contested. Even so, renegotiation of the 1996 treaty, which expires in December, should take into account Bihar's concerns over silt accumulation and the state's river-management needs. The new arrangement needs to be informed by updated data on river flows and climate-change projections. In an era of erratic weather, states and countries sharing river basins should strengthen coordination to manage water flows and mitigate flood-related distress.

AI can kill humanity in a decade? Get in line

IT'S BEEN a while now since reality has all but caught up to the dystopias of science fiction. Take the revelation by Jacob Coxon, a former researcher at Anthropic. “AI,” he said after quitting his job, “could kill us all” by the end of the decade. What's more, there are enough people at companies like Anthropic and OpenAI who are aware of the danger but continue to gamble with smarter models so that they aren't left behind in the race that only billionaires can win. For most people, though, there's only one response to this existential threat to the species: What's all the fuss about?

In the second decade of the 21st century, doomsday is passé. Titans of industry, scientific minds backed by machines of war and just plain old human consumption have taken the planet to the brink of apocalypse. Nuclear weapons, the infamous Doomsday Clock inching towards midnight, floods, heat waves, melting glaciers, rising seas — through it all, people can binge watch and chill. AI could well destroy humanity. It just needs to get in line.

Behind the mass psychosis that drives humans to ever greater peril, despite knowing the danger, is the banality of risk. As members of the only species aware of its own mortality, humans know their existence will come to an end. But like the smoker who puffs away at his cigarette despite knowing the harm, people are likely to ask AI about how to survive the machine apocalypse.

India can change what BRICS stands for — more choices, not more blocs

IT'S AN extraordinary conclave of global leaders. As the BRICS Summit opens today at Bharat Mandapam, the leaders will represent almost half the world's population, 40 per cent of global GDP and over a quarter of global trade. The geopolitics makes the lineup even more exceptional, almost audacious. Narendra Modi will host, amongst others, Russia's Vladimir Putin, South Africa's Cyril Ramaphosa, Iran's Masoud Pezeshkian, Indonesia's Prabowo Subianto, China's Xi Jinping and the UN Secretary-General. Almost miraculous, in these Manichean times.

It will be tempting to judge it, though, as one judges all summits: Can a communiqué survive the night? Can two wars be papered over in a paragraph? And if Xi shows up smiling, is that a thaw? None of these is the real test. Anyone who has attended the drafting of a summit line in this town knows how it goes. It starts with the communiqué and ends with the communiqué, and whatever grand vision India has for the international system two decades from now is considered — politely — by India's diplomats to be somebody else's bailiwick: The professors. The real test is whether India brings an idea to the meeting or is simply a venue for others' ideas.

Surjit Bhalla wrote one for India in this paper yesterday (‘Forget BRICS, look West’, IE, September 10). His maths is not wrong, and neither is his analysis. China will never rebalance. But BRICS was never meant to

be either a growth miracle or a security blanket. To fail it for not being something it never set out to be is to flunk it in the wrong exam. The real mistake comes at the conclusion. Looking West because America has shown itself willing to punish partners who drift is not grand strategy. It is a mere change of address.

BRICS is imbalanced. China pushed hardest for new members. Its bank is in Shanghai. Russia and Iran, the members under Western sanctions, are the ones most interested in de-dollarising their trade. And it is Washington, not Beijing, that now threatens tariffs against any bloc that flirts with a rival to the dollar. Equidistance between America and China is not a policy; it's an assertion of powerlessness. Alignment with either is surrender. What India should do instead is work, quietly, to change what BRICS is for. The world doesn't need more blocs. It needs more choices. A grouping that seats Iran beside the UAE will never agree on ideology, and need not.

The international system, and Asia at its centre, is too large and too plural to be organised around a single axis. India's place in the world gives it both the latitude and the responsibility to say this with conviction. Brazil and South Africa, which gain nothing from either Chinese or American primacy, can say it with the same conviction, and should join Delhi at the table.

The rule applies in the other di-



AMITABH MATTOO

The international system, and Asia at its centre, is too large and too plural to be organised around a single axis. India's place in the world gives it both latitude and responsibility to say this with conviction

AI governance architecture must include its largest stakeholders



SUNIL MEHTA



RICHA ROY

IN THE six weeks that preceded the BRICS Summit in New Delhi, both Demis Hassabis and Bill Gates underscored the need for an AI governance institution, tracking risks across labour, finance, elections, health and beyond. Both emphasised international coordination, yet did not envisage fast-growing emerging markets represented in such institutions.

AI's risks transcend sovereign boundaries and sectoral silos. The chair of the Financial Stability Board (FSB), Andrew Bailey, warned that leverage, stretched valuations and AI optimism are interacting in ways that could amplify a market correction across borders, implying a bubble, a global financial risk. Emerging markets are massive users of AI; their resources, data and labour power its models; they are most vulnerable to its technological, sovereignty, financial and climate risks. The BRICS Summit presents an opportunity to address them.

When India held the 2023 G20 presidency, the authors argued for an International Institute for Regulatory Development (IIRD) under the aegis of the G20 and FSB, to set standards for emergent technologies, undertake global regulatory research, and “tropicalise” rules for fast-growing emerging economies. Three years on, AI sharpens the argument for IIRD. It should be a global apex body for AI, finance and climate risk, with three core functions.

First, research, regulatory capacity-building for early warning. A permanent secretariat producing shared assessments of how AI and other global risks transmit through financial systems and climate exposures, with data drawn from emerging and advanced markets. Existing institutions are inadequate — the FSB is a coordinating umbrella, not a research institute, and the two should complement, not duplicate each other.

Second, an exchange of practice. A living repository of what has worked. The precedents exist. Project Agorá, with 40 private participants such as SWIFT and multiple central banks, and Project Dunbar, in which the central banks of Singapore, Australia, Malaysia and South Africa created a shared platform for digital currencies, show what global regulators can build together. The results of AI pilots in UPI could, for instance, be a valuable part of this exchange.

Third, proportionate standards. Weighted governance that reflects where growth and users are, and a formal channel

into the FSB, the Basel Committee, and climate and frontier-AI bodies. Proportionality matters as much as representation: Standards to be calibrated to contexts.

Given the geopolitical complexity, design choices are critical. The IIRD should be seeded at Delhi, though not owned by BRICS. It should be chartered as an open institution, housed in India, funded by a mix of public, private and multilateral funds, with the New Development Bank as one contributor, and with membership open to the G20, the OECD, multilateral development banks and the FSB.

The IIRD would not threaten the turf of existing institutions, but complement them by producing shared research and early warning on how AI risk transmits through finance and climate, with data from emerging and advanced markets — a gap the FSB itself admits; facilitate a living exchange of practice; feed proportionate, mutually recognised standards into the FSB, Basel; and be a precursor to a global frontier-AI body. The Delhi declaration should mandate a working group, chaired by India and open to non-members, to bring an IIRD charter to the 2027 summit, and to present it in parallel to the G20 finance track — critically, to institutionalise a communiqué.

India's presidencies of global groupings have been praised for being inclusive. As with any international summit, there is the risk of critique of the spectacle surpassing the technical negotiations and sustained institutional engagement. The BRICS IIRD working group offers an opportunity to both retain the inclusivity and preclude the critique.

Bretton Woods institutions originated in America and Europe, designed for a world that no longer exists. AI's governance is being designed by a handful of companies and governments for a world that does not yet exist. Both exclude countries whose citizens will be AI's largest, most vulnerable stakeholders. India's common-law heritage, technological prowess and Global South convening power allow for designing a different architecture. Its BRICS chairship is the moment to offer a third draft, with the Global South as co-creators of the new rules.

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rection, too. Reforming a Western-designed system is a legitimate wish, but a world where Washington is replaced by Beijing as the trusted guarantor of Asian choices simply replaces one centre with another. The harder ambition is an Asia in which China is powerful but not hegemonic, India influential but not domineering, ASEAN does not have to choose, the Gulf defines itself, and the small don't have to be anyone's client states. None of that is “anti-China”. All of it is opposed to hegemony. That distinction is the whole argument.

Three things are within India's reach this weekend. First, an interoperability protocol that links domestic fast-payment systems, building on UPI's existing presence in the Gulf and Southeast Asia and allowing any member to join (or leave) at will. Not a BRICS currency, but a set of alternatives so that no country ever has to rely on a single financial plumbing system. Second, reform of NDB governance that gives newer members more power over its capital. Third, if the sherpas insist on a statement about Ukraine and Gaza, let's make it one about principles, not positions: Not an endorsement of anyone's war aims but a defence of sovereignty which applies to Ukrainians and Gazans alike, and an offer of Indian good offices that this government has, for whatever reason, been extremely reluctant to extend.

When I teach Indian foreign policy at Jawaharlal Nehru University, I teach Kautilya, too. The *mandala* confuses my students for reasons opposite to those I expect. They think an old book will give them hierarchies. They find networks. I call their attention to the inner ring, where the *vijigishu* sits: The king who wishes to conquer. Then you realise that every king in a *mandala* considers himself the *vijigishu*. The map has as many centres as it has points. Hegemony, in Kautilya, isn't how the world is. It's what one powerful ruler wants to make of it, despite all the other *vijigishus*. Asia should settle, instead, for a Kautilyan compromise: A circle of states that can disagree and still cooperate, whose sovereignty is absolute and none of which has the power or the excuse to impose its will on the others.

History is being made whilst we wait. But it isn't made by onlookers. It's hammered out on anvils. For two days this weekend, India is in possession of the anvil. Washington and Beijing wield the hammers. If India can lay ideas on that anvil this weekend, there's a chance Asia will have more than one centre when the dust settles. And if there's one enduring product of this summit that survives the photo-op, let it not be a declaration. Let it be a different question we ask about Asia. Not “Who will dominate?” but “How do we ensure that nobody does?”

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From god of beginnings, sutras for nation-building



SHASHANK R JOSHI



GANAPATI IS not only a god to be worshipped; he is a principle to be lived. Every year, as the *dhool-tasha* announces his arrival, Mumbai stops. India stops. A clay idol becomes the centre of our consciousness.

Why does a form with an elephant head and a human body resonate so deeply with modern, aspirational India? The answer lies in the Vedas. In the Rig Veda, he is “Brahmanaspati”. “*Gananaam tva Ganapatim havamahe, Kavin kavinam upamashravastamam...* (We invoke you, lord of all groups, the wisest of the wise)”. Long before he became the god of beginnings, Ganapati was the Vedic principle of organising chaos into cosmos. “*Gana*” means group, collective, system. “*Pati*” means master. In modern management terms, he is the first systems thinker. Our *rishis* never created a form without philosophy. Each part of Ganesha is a sutra for nation-building.

The elephant head is *maha mastaka* — big intellect, big memory, big vision. An elephant never forgets its path. Viksit Bharat needs this big head to think 25 years ahead, to remember our civilisational roots while embracing AI, biotech, and quantum. Next is *shurpa karna*, the winnowing ears. His ears are like winnowing fans. He listens to everything but retains only the grain, throws away the chaff. In the age of social media noise, fake news and polarisation, this is our greatest *sadhana*. *Viveka* is to listen to all stakeholders — farmer, jawan, scientist, youth — but to keep only what is true and useful for the nation. *Vakratunda*, the curved trunk, is adaptability. His trunk can uproot a tree and pick up a needle. That is flexibility with strength. Viksit Bharat will need this to be strong on borders and soft in welfare. The *mushaka vahana*, the mouse, is the most profound symbol. A tiny mouse carries this huge god. The mouse is *iccha* — desire, consumption, greed that nibbles away everything. If desire rides us, we are destroyed. If wisdom rides desire, we progress. The climate crisis, our sugar epidemic, our consumerism — can be controlled only when *buddhi* rides over *bhoga*. That is why Ganesha comes before Lakshmi. Wealth without wisdom is *vinasha*. Finally, “modak in hand”. The *sadhana* modak is not just sweet. It is the sweet fruit of disciplined effort — *purushartha*. Viksit Bharat will not come by slogans, but by the tapas of every Indian.

We call him Vighnaharta — remover of obstacles. But his Vedic name is also Vighnakarta — he creates obstacles for the egoistic. Every obstacle in our path to becoming a developed nation — corruption, casteism, pollution of our rivers, lifestyle diseases — is actually his grace. He is blocking the wrong path, so we take the right one.

Ecological Ganesha will let the clay return to clay. Let our *visarjan* be *visarjana* — letting go of ego, not polluting water. The Vedas say — *mrityiiva mritim* — from earth to earth. The economic Ganapati Bappa will let our modak be made of millets — *shree anna* — linking our farmers to our festivals. That is true *atmanirbharta*. Finally, the spiritual Bappa: Before starting any new venture for Viksit Bharat — a startup, a lab, a school — invoke the Ganapati principle: Will this organise or disorganise? Will this serve the *gana* or only me? Ganesh Chaturthi is not 10 days of noise. It is 10 days of training for the mind to become *sthita pragnya* — stable in wisdom, like his belly that holds the entire universe yet stays calm.

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40 YEARS AGO

September 12, 1986



28 killed in train-bus collision

AT LEAST 28 bus passengers were killed and over 60 injured, several of them seriously, in a major train-bus collision at an unmanned level-crossing at Pathalipahar in the north Lakhimpur district of Upper Assam, bordering Arunachal Pradesh, according to the latest official reports reaching Guwahati. Forty-eight passengers were admitted to hospitals. A spokesman of NF Railway said the collision occurred as the bus driver failed to observe necessary caution.

PM on border security

THE PRIME Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, said the

Centre would not hesitate to take steps under the powers granted by the Rajya Sabha to counter any attempt by the Punjab government that might weaken border security. Gandhi was reacting to the state government's decision to appoint an enquiry committee to go into the recent incident on the India-Pakistan border when 13 alleged terrorists were killed in an encounter with the BSF

The Gorkha question

THE LEFT Front government wants to handle the GNLF-led movement for a separate state in Darjeeling purely as a political problem. It was ready to extend autonomy to the region, but under no circumstances would it allow Gorkha leaders to carry on any anti-national

or divisive movement. This was stated by Chief Minister Jyoti Basu at a press conference. Basu said that secessionist and divisive forces should not find any element of inspiration in any section of the press.

NCERT silver jubilee

ON THE occasion of the silver jubilee celebrations of the National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT), the Prime Minister, Rajiv Gandhi, awarded fellowships of the National Institute of Education to 19 eminent educationists. Inaugurating the silver jubilee celebrations, the Prime Minister said that the new education policy (NEP) was designed to make the nation's vast human resources an asset instead of a liability.